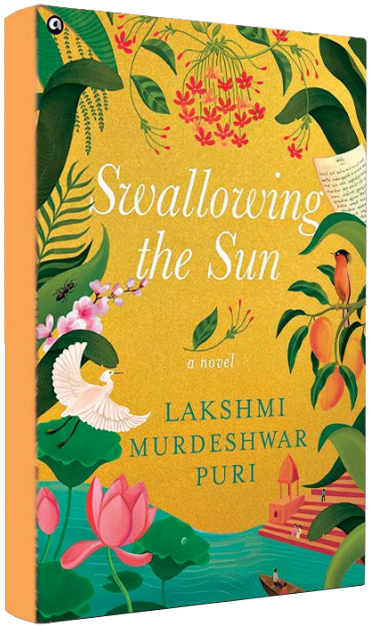
BOOKS

The Daughter Also Rises

In her debut novel Swallowing the Sun, ***Lakshmi Murdeshwar Puri has crafted a historical narrative about her protagonist, Malati, forging her own identity***



SWALLOWING THE SUN
A Novel
by Lakshmi Murdeshwar Puri
ALEPH BOOK COMPANY
₹899; 424 pages

Lakshmi Murdeshwar Puri's debut novel *Swallowing the Sun* begins with its young protagonist, Malati, negotiating that quintessential childhood quagmire—standing up to a schoolyard bully. In Malati's case, it's an arrogant boy who does not believe girls can ever be his equals. Malati ends up wrestling him, inflicting an embarrassing defeat using superior tactics. This is the first of many occasions across the novel where Malati challenges the gendered status quo in her immediate environs.

Set in the first half of the 20th century amidst India's struggle for independence, *Swallowing the Sun* is the story of Malati, her progressive parents and the man she eventually falls for—the fight against British colonial rule weaves in and out of their personal lives, usually to present a nation-vs-self dilemma before these characters. The novel derives its name and central ethos from a 13th-century *abhanga* that speaks of an ant flying into the sky and swallowing the sun. As we see Malati and her folks smashing one taboo after another—getting their local school to admit girls, Malati pursuing a legal degree, even providing her unemployed husband with an income at one point—we see the ants-swallowing-the-sun metaphor for the inspirational, albeit cryptic pep-talk it is.

At every stage of her journey, there are setbacks and defeats, of course. For example, Malati's father's initial attempt to get girls enrolled in the local school are nipped in the bud. These passages are intelligently and sensitively executed by Puri, who in the past has headed several women's empowerment initiatives by the United Nations, where she served as Assistant Secretary General.

British colonial rule weaves through personal lives, presenting a **NATION-VS-SELF** dilemma before the characters

I also enjoyed the roles (direct or indirect) played by historical figures like Gandhi and Sarojini Naidu in the text. Over and above their actual 'cameos' (the scene where Malati meets Gandhi is adorable in its sincerity), it is their written words that act as inspiration for Malati and the people around her. Allusions to John Bunyan and Rudyard Kipling serve a similar purpose, especially for the British characters in the story.

Where *Swallowing the Sun* falls a bit short of the mark is in its dialogue, which is wooden on occasion and feels too much like exposition for exposition's sake. A husband-and-wife duo speaking in the privacy of their bedroom seldom break into phrases like "capricious narcissism". At another point, Malati's husband Guru says, "It's that time in my life, where I am on the brink of greatness. I need a devotee. Will you be mine?" To be honest, that feels more like a screenplay than a real conversation. The second half of the novel could also have used firmer editing and 70-80 pages could well have been shaved off the manuscript.

Overall, though, these are small complaints in a minor key. For much of its length, *Swallowing the Sun* is an intelligent, genteel historical novel about a nation—and its women—finding their voices. ■

—Aditya Mani Jha